

Deploying the future of SMS

We sat down with Route Mobile to discuss the Rich Communication Services (RCS) protocol, an upgrade over the existing SMS protocol.



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Q Why did it take so long for a new protocol to be standardized?

Rajdip: Sending an SMS is effortless, it involves a simple architecture to achieve easy interconnectivity. RCS uses multiple rich mediums to communicate, hence interconnectivity to support these rich media is required. To enable RCS interoperability across the globe, GSMA has defined certain standards which are being implemented by various operators and hub providers. Both carrier and device support are crucial to enable RCS. This is being done but, at a slow pace. A2P (application to person) and P2P (peer to peer) communication have an array of advantages. RCS is comparatively more interactive and reduces the dependency on other OTT apps. In addition, chatbots integration for providing support to the enterprises aims to make the process simpler and cost-effective. As a result, carriers will be able to monetise the messaging revenue which is currently taken over by other OTT players. Hence, we can be sure that RCS is the future of SMS.

Q Are there any security benefits over SMS, since RCS doesn't support end-to-end encryption?

Rajdip: RCS messaging is one of the most secure forms of digital com-

munication available today. In order to enable transmission of messages to its end users, a company has to go through a brand verification process done by Hub providers. This process safeguards users from spammers, fraudulent texts, and PPI claims, completely eliminating the drawbacks faced by SMS. Moreover, users will have the authority to block or mark the communication channel as spam from where the messages are delivered to the end-user. The spam filter employed here will be very similar to the filters available in our mailboxes.

Q Which telecom carriers in India are upgrading networks to enable RCS?

Rajdip: Multiple operators are upgrading their services to bring in compatibility with RCS. Enabling RCS interconnectivity is difficult and a time-consuming process. More so, the entire infrastructure will have to be upgraded. Also, in order to share rich media, it will require additional storage devices which would increase the cost.

Owing to the newness of RCS, carriers are not sure about the ROI after enabling these services. The revenue generated will be shared between all the operators and service providers after scheduling/delivering messages. As all the players across the globe are progressing towards enabling the ser-

vice, handset providers will also have to upgrade their apps to support RCS.

Google is coming up with JIBE and RBM platform to enable A2P players in providing multiple services over RCS.

Q Will users be able to use existing SMS mobile apps for RCS messaging?

Rajdip: With time, all your SMS apps on Android phones will get upgraded and become RCS enabled. Also, there has to be a default app for transmitting SMS on the phone. All messaging apps provided by multiple players over the Android ecosystem will be upgraded to support RCS. Currently, in India, there are a few apps and carriers that support RCS. It can be used for P2P communication in India.

Q By when can we see RCS being rolled out in India?

Rajdip: Route Mobile is the first Indian brand to bring RCS in India by participating in Google's Early Access Program. We are in the process of building our own infrastructure for running RCS campaigns and integrating it with our bot platform. Currently, we are running trials for some of our clients in India for PoC. Along with this, Bot self-service eradicates the dependency on contact centre by providing 24x7 support.

We aim to complete the ecosystem and go live in the 1st quarter of 2019. **[d]**